The AI Stack Minimalist

How to Build a 3-App Daily Workflow That Actually Saves You 10 Hours a Week

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Introduction: You Don't Have a Tool Problem. You Have a Stack Problem.

You didn't sign up for chaos. You signed up for leverage.

One AI app to write faster. Another to summarize meetings. A third for images, a fourth for research, a fifth because someone on LinkedIn said it "changed everything." Each one promised to save you time.

Add it up honestly and the opposite happened.

You now spend your mornings deciding which tool to open instead of doing the work.

The hidden cost of AI tool fatigue

Tool bloat doesn't show up as one big expense. It leaks out in four places:

- **Money.** Five to eight subscriptions at $10–$30 each quietly becomes $100–$200 a month. Many overlap 70% in what they do.
- **Context.** Every app holds a different slice of your work. Your notes live in one place, your drafts in another, your prompts in a third. Nothing talks to anything.
- **Switching.** Each jump between apps costs you re-orientation time. Do it 30 times a day and you've lost an hour before lunch.
- **Decision energy.** "Which tool should I use for this?" is a question you answer dozens of times a day. That's willpower you should be spending on actual work.

> **The real problem:** More tools means more inputs, more logins, more places your work can hide. Complexity scales faster than capability.

The philosophy of subtraction

This guide runs on one principle: **the best AI stack is the smallest one that covers every job you actually do.**

Not the most powerful. Not the newest. The smallest.

You'll build a stack of exactly **three apps**, each with one clear job:

1. **Reasoning** — where you think, write, and analyze.
2. **Automation** — where repetitive work runs without you.
3. **Knowledge** — where everything you know and produce lives.

That's it. Three layers, three apps, one daily workflow.

Where the 10 hours come from

This isn't a magic number. It's what typically comes back when you stop paying the switching tax and start reusing systems instead of improvising:

Source of time saved	Per day	Per week (5 days)
Fewer app switches and re-orientations	35 min	~3 hrs
Reusable prompt templates instead of writing from scratch	30 min	2.5 hrs
Automated capture, sorting, and follow-ups	25 min	~2 hrs
Finding notes and past work in one place	20 min	~1.5 hrs
Fewer "which tool?" decisions and tool tinkering	10 min	~1 hr
Total	**~2 hrs**	**~10 hrs**

Your numbers will vary. The audit in Module 1 shows you exactly where yours are.

> **How to use this guide:** Read it once straight through (about 40 minutes). Then do the Quick-Start Checklist at the end within 24 hours. Momentum matters more than perfection.

Module 1: The AI Overwhelm Audit

You can't simplify what you haven't measured. This audit takes 45–60 minutes and shows you exactly what to keep, what to merge, and what to cut.

Don't skip it. Most people who skip the audit just rebuild the same mess with fewer logos.

Step 1: Build your tool inventory (15 minutes)

Open your bank or card statements for the last 90 days. Then open your browser bookmarks, your phone's home screen, and your browser extensions.

List **every** AI tool or AI-powered app you touch. Include free ones. Include the ones you forgot you were paying for.

For each tool, fill one row of this table:

Tool	Monthly cost	Last used	Days used (last 30)	Main job it does	Overlaps with
Example: AI writing app	$20	3 weeks ago	2	Blog drafts	General chat assistant

> **Reality check:** If you can't remember the last time you used a tool, write "unknown." Unknown almost always means "cut."

Step 2: Map your actual jobs (15 minutes)

Forget the tools for a moment. Write down the **jobs** you do every week. Be specific.

Common jobs for solopreneurs, remote workers, and creators:

- Writing (emails, posts, proposals, scripts)
- Researching and summarizing
- Planning the day or week
- Processing meeting notes and turning them into tasks
- Repurposing content across formats
- Answering repetitive questions (clients, customers, team)
- Capturing ideas and finding them again later
- Moving information between apps (forms → spreadsheet → email)

Now tag each job with the layer it belongs to:

- **R = Reasoning** (thinking, writing, analyzing)
- **A = Automation** (repeatable, rule-based, happens without judgment)
- **K = Knowledge** (storing, organizing, retrieving)

You'll notice something: **almost every job fits one of three buckets.** That's the foundation of Module 2.

Step 3: Run the 5-question keep-or-cut test (15 minutes)

Run every tool on your inventory through these five questions. Score 1 point for each "yes."

- [ ] **Frequency:** Did I use it on at least 8 of the last 30 days?
- [ ] **Uniqueness:** Does it do something no other tool on my list can do reasonably well?
- [ ] **Outcome:** Can I name one specific result (money earned, hours saved, client won) it produced in the last month?
- [ ] **Integration:** Does it connect to the rest of my workflow, or is it an island?
- [ ] **Replacement pain:** If it vanished tomorrow, would I feel it within a week?

Score it:

Score	Verdict	Action
5	Core	Candidate for your 3-app stack
3–4	Merge	Check if a core tool can absorb its job
0–2	Cut	Cancel this week

Step 4: Find your overlaps (10 minutes)

Look at the "Overlaps with" column. Circle every pair of tools that do the same job.

The usual suspects:

- A general AI chat assistant **plus** a separate AI writing app **plus** a separate AI summarizer. One good reasoning app does all three.
- A note-taking app **plus** a separate "AI second brain" **plus** a bookmark manager. One knowledge app does all three.
- Two automation services running a handful of workflows each. Consolidate into one.

> **Rule of overlap:** When two tools overlap, keep the one with the **broader** capability and the **better export options**, not the one with the nicer interface.

Step 5: Total the damage

Fill in three numbers. Write them somewhere you'll see them.

- **Total monthly spend on AI tools:** $____
- **Number of tools scoring 0–2:** ____
- **Projected monthly savings after cuts:** $____

This is your baseline. You'll compare against it in 30 days.

The AI Overwhelm Audit — summary checklist

- [ ] Listed every AI tool from statements, bookmarks, phone, and extensions
- [ ] Filled in cost, last used, and days used for each
- [ ] Listed my weekly jobs and tagged each R, A, or K
- [ ] Scored every tool with the 5-question test
- [ ] Circled all overlaps
- [ ] Totaled spend and projected savings
- [ ] Cancelled at least one 0–2 tool today

Module 2: The Lean 3-App Architecture

Three layers. One app per layer. Each app has one job and does it well. Everything you do in a day flows through this loop:

Knowledge feeds context into **Reasoning** → **Reasoning** produces outputs → **Automation** moves those outputs where they need to go → results flow back into **Knowledge**.

Layer	Its one job	What it replaces	Example apps (pick ONE)
Reasoning	Think, write, analyze, decide	AI writers, summarizers, research assistants, brainstorm tools	Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini
Automation	Move data and trigger actions without you	Manual copy-paste, reminders, follow-up tasks, niche single-purpose bots	Zapier, Make, n8n

Layer	Its one job	What it replaces	Example apps (pick ONE)
Knowledge	Store, organize, and retrieve everything	Scattered notes apps, bookmark tools, "second brain" add-ons, random docs	Notion, Obsidian, Google Drive

> **The brand doesn't matter. The role does.** Pick the app you already know best in each layer. Familiarity beats features every time.

Layer 1: Reasoning — your thinking partner

This is the **only** place you have conversations with AI. Writing, research, analysis, planning, editing, brainstorming: all of it happens here.

How to choose your Reasoning app:

1. Look at your audit. Which general AI assistant scored highest?
2. Confirm it handles long documents and file uploads (PDFs, spreadsheets).
3. Confirm it supports **saved instructions** — projects, custom instructions, or reusable context. This is what turns a chatbot into a system.
4. Pay for **one** paid plan. Cancel every other AI writing, summarizing, or chat subscription.

How to set it up (30 minutes):

1. Create a saved context (a "project" or custom instruction set) called **"My Operating Context."**
2. Paste in: who you are, what you do, who your audience or clients are, your tone of voice, and three examples of your best writing.
3. Add your hard rules. For example: "No corporate jargon. Short paragraphs. Always end with a concrete next step."
4. Create a second saved context for your biggest recurring project (a client, a content series, a product).

> **Why this matters:** Without saved context, you re-explain yourself in every chat. With it, every conversation starts at 80% instead of 0%.

Layer 2: Automation — your invisible assistant

This layer runs work **without you opening anything.** If you do the same sequence of clicks more than twice a week, it belongs here.

How to choose your Automation app:

- **Want simple and fast?** Choose the one with the largest library of ready-made integrations.
- **Want visual, multi-step flows at lower cost?** Choose a visual scenario builder.
- **Technical and want full control or self-hosting?** Choose an open-source option.

Your first three automations (build these in week one):

1. **Capture → Knowledge.** Anything you save, star, or forward (emails, links, voice notes) lands automatically in a single **Inbox** page or folder in your Knowledge app.
2. **Meeting → Tasks.** When a meeting transcript or notes file appears, it's sent to your Reasoning app (or an AI step inside your automation tool) to extract action items, which are added to your task list.
3. **Form or lead → Follow-up.** When someone fills in your contact form or books a call, they get a confirmation email and a row is added to your client tracker.

> **The 2-minute rule for automation:** Only automate a task if it happens at least weekly and takes more than 2 minutes each time. Otherwise, the setup costs more than it saves.

Layer 3: Knowledge — your single source of truth

This is where **everything you know and make** lives. Notes, drafts, finished work, your prompt library, client files, research.

One place. Searchable. Yours.

How to choose your Knowledge app:

1. Pick the app where most of your notes **already** live. Migration is the most expensive part of switching.
2. Confirm it exports cleanly (Markdown, CSV, or standard documents). If you can't get your data out, you don't own it.
3. Confirm your Automation app can write into it.

The minimalist folder structure (create exactly these five, nothing else):

- **00 Inbox** — everything lands here first. Cleared weekly.
- **01 Active** — projects with a deadline in the next 90 days.
- **02 Resources** — reference material, research, swipe files.
- **03 Prompts** — your prompt library (see Module 3).
- **04 Archive** — finished or paused work. Never delete; just move here.

> **Rule:** If you can't decide where something goes, it goes in Inbox. Decide on Friday.

How the three layers work together: a sample day

Time	Layer	What happens
8:00	Automation	Overnight emails, saved links, and form submissions already sorted into your Inbox
8:15	Reasoning	Run the Daily Command Center prompt (Module 3) with your Inbox and calendar pasted in
8:30	Knowledge	Save today's plan to 01 Active
9:00–12:00	Reasoning	Deep work: draft, research, analyze using saved context and prompt templates
13:00	Automation	Meeting notes auto-sent for action-item extraction; tasks created
15:00	Reasoning	Run the Content Repurposing Engine on one finished piece
17:00	Knowledge	Final outputs filed; tomorrow's top 3 noted

Notice what's missing: **no app-hopping, no hunting for files, no deciding which AI to ask.**

Module 3: Plug-and-Play Daily Prompt Frameworks

Stop writing prompts from scratch. Write them once, reuse them forever. These three templates cover the core of a solopreneur's day: planning, producing, and multiplying.

How to use them:

1. Copy each template into your **03 Prompts** folder in your Knowledge app.

2. Replace everything in `[SQUARE BRACKETS]` with your details.
3. Paste into your Reasoning app, ideally inside your "My Operating Context" project so it already knows who you are.
4. After each use, tweak one line that would have made the output better. Your templates get sharper every week.

> **Prompt anatomy:** Every template below follows the same structure — **Role → Context → Inputs → Task → Constraints → Output format.** Use it for any prompt you write yourself.

Template 1: The Daily Command Center

Use it: Every morning, before you open email. Takes 5 minutes. Replaces 30 minutes of scattered planning.

```
ROLE: You are my chief of staff. Your job is to protect my focus and make
sure the most important work gets done today.

CONTEXT:
- My role: [YOUR ROLE, e.g., freelance brand designer]
- My top goal this quarter: [QUARTERLY GOAL]
- My top goal this week: [WEEKLY GOAL]
- Hours available for focused work today: [NUMBER] hours
- My energy level today (1-10): [NUMBER]

INPUTS:
Calendar for today:
[PASTE TODAY'S CALENDAR]

Open tasks and inbox items:
[PASTE TASK LIST / INBOX ITEMS]

Unfinished items from yesterday:
[PASTE OR WRITE "NONE"]

TASK:
1. Identify the ONE task that would make today a success if it were the only
thing I finished. Explain why in one sentence.
2. Pick two more supporting tasks (maximum).
3. Build a time-blocked schedule around my existing meetings. Put the most
important task in my first available 90-minute block.
```

```
4. List every remaining task under one of: DELEGATE, AUTOMATE, DEFER (with a
date), or DELETE.
5. Flag anything that looks urgent but is not actually important.

CONSTRAINTS:
- Do not schedule more than [NUMBER] hours of focused work.
- Leave a 15-minute buffer after every meeting.
- Be blunt. If my list is unrealistic, say so.

OUTPUT FORMAT:
- "Today's One Thing" (1 line)
- "Supporting Tasks" (2 bullets)
- "Schedule" (table: Time | Task)
- "Delegate / Automate / Defer / Delete" (4 short lists)
- "Watch Out" (1–2 lines)
```

> **Pro tip:** Once this works for a week, have your Automation app compile your calendar and inbox items into a single morning note. Then you only paste one thing.

Template 2: The Deep Work Draft Engine

Use it: Whenever you need to produce something substantial — a proposal, article, client email, script, report. Replaces the blank-page problem and three rounds of rewrites.

```
ROLE: You are a senior [TYPE OF EXPERT, e.g., conversion copywriter / B2B
consultant / technical writer] who writes clearly and gets to the point.

CONTEXT:
- What I'm creating: [DELIVERABLE, e.g., a project proposal]
- Who it's for: [AUDIENCE, including what they care about and what they
already know]
- What I want them to do after reading: [DESIRED ACTION]
- My tone of voice: [3 ADJECTIVES, e.g., direct, warm, confident]

INPUTS:
My raw notes, ideas, or outline:
[PASTE NOTES — messy is fine]

Reference material (optional):
[PASTE RESEARCH, PREVIOUS EXAMPLES, OR DATA]

TASK:
```

```
Step 1 — Before writing, ask me up to 3 clarifying questions if anything
critical is missing. If nothing is missing, say "Ready" and continue.
Step 2 — Propose a structure: a headline/subject line plus 4–7 section
headings with one line each describing the point of that section.
Step 3 — After I approve or adjust the structure, write the full draft.
Step 4 — End with a short self-critique: the 2 weakest parts of the draft and
how to fix them.

CONSTRAINTS:
- Length: [TARGET LENGTH, e.g., 600–800 words]
- No filler phrases, no clichés, no corporate jargon.
- Short paragraphs (max 3 sentences).
- Every claim must be specific. Use the numbers and examples from my notes.
- Do not invent facts, statistics, or quotes. If something needs a source,
mark it [CHECK].

OUTPUT FORMAT:
Plain text with headings, ready to paste into [DESTINATION, e.g., Google Docs
/ email / my CMS].
```

> **Why the clarifying questions step works:** It forces the AI to find the gaps before it fills them with generic filler. One minute of questions saves twenty minutes of editing.

Template 3: The Content Repurposing Engine

Use it: Once per day on one finished piece of work. Turns one asset into a week of distribution. Replaces separate social, newsletter, and short-form AI tools.

```
ROLE: You are a content strategist who specializes in adapting one core idea
into native formats for different platforms, without losing the substance.

CONTEXT:
- My audience: [WHO THEY ARE AND WHAT PROBLEM THEY HAVE]
- My platforms: [LIST, e.g., LinkedIn, newsletter, X, YouTube Shorts]
- My positioning: [ONE SENTENCE ON WHAT YOU'RE KNOWN FOR]
- Call to action I want to drive: [CTA, e.g., book a call / download my guide
/ reply to this email]

INPUT:
Source content:
```

```
[PASTE ARTICLE, TRANSCRIPT, CLIENT RESULT, OR NOTES]

TASK:
1. Extract the 3 strongest ideas, insights, or stories from the source. Rank
them by how useful they are to my audience.
2. For the #1 idea, create:
   a. One [PLATFORM 1] post ([LENGTH, e.g., 150–200 words]) with a hook in
the first line.
   b. One [PLATFORM 2] piece ([FORMAT, e.g., newsletter section of 250
words]).
   c. One short-form video script (under 60 seconds): hook, 3 beats, CTA.
3. For ideas #2 and #3, write one hook line and a 3-bullet outline each, so I
can develop them later.
4. Suggest the best day and order to publish these this week.

CONSTRAINTS:
- Each piece must stand on its own. No "as I said in my last post."
- Write natively for each platform's style; don't just shorten the same text.
- Keep my voice: [VOICE NOTES, e.g., plain language, light humor, no
hashtags].
- Every piece ends with the CTA, adapted to the platform.

OUTPUT FORMAT:
Separate sections with clear headings per platform, ready to copy and paste.
```

> **Close the loop:** Save every output to **01 Active** in your Knowledge app. Have your Automation app push approved posts to your scheduler. One finished piece becomes 5–7 assets with about 15 minutes of review.

Bonus: The Prompt Upgrade Prompt

Use this once a month on any template that's underperforming.

```
Here is a prompt I use regularly:
[PASTE PROMPT]

Here is an output it produced that I wasn't happy with:
[PASTE OUTPUT]

Here is what I actually wanted:
[DESCRIBE THE GAP]

Rewrite my prompt so it reliably produces what I want. Keep the same
structure (Role, Context, Inputs, Task, Constraints, Output format). Explain
each change in one line.
```

Module 4: Maintenance & Future-Proofing

A lean stack doesn't stay lean by accident. New AI tools launch every week, and every one of them is designed to make you feel behind. These rules keep your stack small and your data clean.

The 7 Rules Against Tool Creep

Rule 1: One in, one out. You may add a new tool only if you remove one. Your stack never grows past three core apps.

Rule 2: The 30-day waiting list. When you see a shiny new tool, don't sign up. Add it to a "Tool Wishlist" note in **02 Resources**. If you still want it in 30 days, run it through the audit test. Most won't survive.

Rule 3: Prove the gap first. Before trying anything new, write down the specific job your current stack **cannot** do. "It looks cool" is not a gap. "My Reasoning app can't process 2-hour video files" is.

Rule 4: Features before apps. Your three apps ship new features constantly. Before adding a tool, check whether one of your existing apps added that capability in the last 3 months.

Rule 5: Trial with a kill date. If a tool passes Rules 1–4, trial it for 14 days on one real project. Put the cancellation date in your calendar **the day you sign up.**

Rule 6: No annual plans for new tools. Pay monthly until a tool has been in your stack for 6 months. The discount isn't worth the lock-in.

Rule 7: Integration or exit. If a tool can't connect to your Automation app or export to your Knowledge app, it doesn't get in. Islands become graveyards.

> **The FOMO test:** Ask yourself, "Will this help me finish what I'm working on this month?" If the answer is no, it's entertainment, not productivity.

Data hygiene: keep your Knowledge layer clean

Your Knowledge app is only as useful as it is findable. Garbage in, garbage retrieved.

Naming convention (use it for every file and note):

`YYYY-MM-DD – Type – Topic`

Examples:

- `2026-10-13 – Proposal – Acme rebrand`
- `2026-10-13 – Meeting – Weekly client sync`
- `2026-10-13 – Prompt – Daily Command Center v3`

Data hygiene rules:

- **Everything enters through Inbox.** No exceptions. Nothing gets filed directly into a folder without being looked at.
- **AI outputs are drafts until you edit them.** Tag unedited AI output with `#draft` so you never mistake it for verified work.
- **Version your prompts.** When you improve a template, save it as v2, v3. Keep the old one in Archive so you can roll back.
- **Never paste sensitive data you wouldn't email.** Client passwords, financial account numbers, ID numbers, and confidential contracts stay out of AI chats. Check your Reasoning app's data and training settings and opt out of anything you're not comfortable with.
- **Own your exports.** Your data should never exist in only one place.

The maintenance rhythm

Put these four recurring events in your calendar right now.

Cadence	Time needed	What you do
Daily	5 min	Run Template 1. File today's outputs from Inbox at day's end.
Weekly (Friday)	20 min	Empty **00 Inbox**. Move finished projects to Archive. Check automations ran without errors. Update one prompt template.
Monthly	30 min	Review every subscription charge. Back up / export your Knowledge app. Review the Tool Wishlist against the 7 Rules.
Quarterly	60 min	Re-run the full Module 1 audit. Test whether each of your 3 apps is still the best fit for its layer. Delete automations you no longer need.

Future-proofing: how to survive the next wave of AI

AI tools will change. Your system shouldn't have to.

- **Your prompts are portable.** Because they're stored as plain text in your Knowledge app, you can move them to any Reasoning app in minutes.
- **Your context is portable.** Keep your "My Operating Context" text saved as a note too, not only inside your AI app.
- **Your automations are documented.** For each automation, keep a one-line note in **02 Resources**: Trigger → Action → Destination. If you switch automation tools, you rebuild from the list, not from memory.
- **Swap apps, not layers.** If a better Reasoning app appears, you replace one app. The architecture, folders, prompts, and habits all stay.

> **The bottom line:** Tools are temporary. Systems compound. Invest your time in the system.

Conclusion: Less Stack, More Output

You don't need more AI. You need **less AI, used deliberately.**

Here's what you now have:

- **An audit** that shows exactly where your money and attention leak.
- **An architecture** of three layers — Reasoning, Automation, Knowledge — that covers every job you do.
- **Three prompt templates** that plan your day, produce your best work, and multiply its reach.
- **A maintenance system** that keeps your stack lean as the AI market keeps shouting.

The people who win with AI over the next few years won't be the ones with the most tools. They'll be the ones with the **clearest systems.**

That's you now. Go build it.

> **Remember:** Done in 24 hours beats perfect in 24 days. Your first version will be rough. Run it for a week, then improve it.

Quick-Start Checklist: Your Next 24 Hours

Work through these in order. Total time: about 3 hours, spread across today and tomorrow.

Hour 1: Audit and cut

- [ ] Pull 90 days of statements and list every AI tool you pay for or use (15 min)
- [ ] Score each tool with the 5-question keep-or-cut test (15 min)
- [ ] **Cancel at least one subscription that scored 0–2. Right now.** (5 min)
- [ ] Write down your current monthly AI spend and projected savings (5 min)
- [ ] Choose your one Reasoning, one Automation, and one Knowledge app (20 min)

Hour 2: Set up the stack

- [ ] Create your "My Operating Context" saved instructions in your Reasoning app (20 min)
- [ ] Create the five folders in your Knowledge app: 00 Inbox, 01 Active, 02 Resources, 03 Prompts, 04 Archive (10 min)
- [ ] Build your first automation: Capture → Inbox (30 min)

Hour 3: Run the workflow

- [ ] Copy all three prompt templates (plus the Prompt Upgrade Prompt) into **03 Prompts** and fill in your fixed variables (20 min)
- [ ] Tomorrow morning: run the Daily Command Center before opening email (10 min)
- [ ] Use the Deep Work Draft Engine on your most important task of the day (variable)
- [ ] Run the Content Repurposing Engine on one finished piece (15 min)

Lock it in

- [ ] Add the weekly (Friday, 20 min), monthly (30 min), and quarterly (60 min) maintenance blocks to your calendar
- [ ] Create a "Tool Wishlist" note in **02 Resources** for anything new you're tempted by
- [ ] Set a reminder 30 days from today to compare your spend and hours against your baseline

> **Your 30-day scorecard:** In one month, answer three questions. How much did I save per month? How many hours did I get back per week? What's one template I improved? Write the answers in your Knowledge app. That's your proof the system works.